

more than 7,700 employees and annual revenues in the billions, Intuit is not a typical startup.²

The team that built SnapTax doesn't look much like the archetypal image of entrepreneurs either. They don't work in a garage or eat ramen noodles. Their company doesn't lack for resources. They are paid a full salary and benefits. They come into a regular office every day. Yet they are entrepreneurs.

Stories like this one are not nearly as common inside large corporations as they should be. After all, SnapTax competes directly with one of Intuit's flagship products: the fully featured TurboTax desktop software. Usually, companies like Intuit fall into the trap described in Clayton Christensen's *The Innovator's Dilemma*: they are very good at creating incremental improvements to existing products and serving existing customers, which Christensen called sustaining innovation, but struggle to create breakthrough new products—disruptive innovation—that can create new sustainable sources of growth.

One remarkable part of the SnapTax story is what the team leaders said when I asked them to account for their unlikely success. Did they hire superstar entrepreneurs from outside the company? No, they assembled a team from within Intuit. Did they face constant meddling from senior management, which is the bane of innovation teams in many companies? No, their executive sponsors created an “island of freedom” where they could experiment as necessary. Did they have a huge team, a large budget, and lots of marketing dollars? Nope, they started with a team of five.

What allowed the SnapTax team to innovate was not their genes, destiny, or astrological signs but a process deliberately facilitated by Intuit's senior management. Innovation is a bottoms-up, decentralized, and unpredictable thing, but that doesn't mean it cannot be managed. It can, but to do so requires a new management discipline, one that needs to be mastered not just by practicing entrepreneurs seeking to build the next big thing but also by the people who support them, nurture them, and hold them accountable. In other words, cultivating entrepreneurship is the